
OVERVIEW

The Michigan Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer (SEBT) program is a federally funded program that provides grocery-buying benefits to low-income families with school-age children when schools are closed for summer as a supplement to summer meal sites. This may include students in Head Start and/or Great Start Readiness Program (GSRP).

The Michigan Department of Education (MDE) will be partnering with the Michigan Department of Health and Human Services (MDHHS) for the SEBT program administration and eligibility determination.

ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

A child is eligible for SEBT if:

- Household participants, between the ages of 6 to 18, who receive Food Assistance Program (FAP), Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF), Food Distribution Program on Indian reservations (FDPIR), or eligible Medical Assistance (MA) households at or below 185% of the federal poverty level; or
- Students of any age receiving free or reduced priced lunch through the National School Lunch Program (NSLP)/School Breakfast Program (SBP); or
- An approved Summer EBT application, MDHHS-6138, Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) Application.

STREAMLINED CERTIFICATION

MDHHS will identify eligible children for SEBT using program eligibility for FAP, TANF, FDPIR, and eligible MA households at or below 185% of the federal poverty level. Children ages 6 to 18 who are/were active during any month from July of the previous year through the end of the current year's summer period. This includes children who are categorically eligible (foster, unsheltered, migrant, or a runaway).

Example: For the year 2025, a child would need to be active on one of the programs for one month during the period of July 1st, 2024, to August 31st, 2025.

MDE will provide information for eligible children of any age that are attending a NSLP/SBP school who qualified from direct certification, or have an approved application from the school, or is categorically eligible.

Information from MDHHS and MDE will be combined and deduplicated. Eligible children will automatically be issued the SEBT benefit.

APPLICATION

Children who are enrolled in NSLP/SBP schools can establish eligibility for SEBT by submitting an application (MDHHS-6138, Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) Application). The application can be submitted electronically, or a paper application can be submitted. Households can establish eligibility for SEBT up to the last day of the summer operational period, August 31st of each year.

- Must be currently residing in Michigan and enrolled in a NSLP/SBP participating school.
- Households must be income eligible based on free or reduced priced lunch guidelines. Applications submitted are evaluated on the income eligibility guidelines that are in effect when the application is submitted.

Note: Household means a group of related or nonrelated individuals, who are not residents of an institution or boarding house, but who are living together sharing income and expenses.

- Children who are not enrolled in a NSLP/SBP participating school and not eligible through streamlined certification, are **not** eligible.
- A completed application with a signature certifies that all information furnished is true and correct, that all income is reported, and the application is being made in connection with the receipt of federal funds. It also certifies that the applicant is not already receiving SEBT benefits in another state or Indian Tribal Organization (ITO) and that the state or local school officials may verify the accuracy of information on the application. If false information is purposely given, the child

may be denied benefits, and applicant may be prosecuted under state and federal criminal laws.

Once the processing of applications begins at initial issuance:

- If the submitted application is not complete or does not meet eligibility criteria, the denial notice must be provided to households within 15 business days of receipt of the application.
- If the application of an eligible household is approved, notice of approval must be provided to household within 15 business days of receipt of a completed application.

For applications received during the period of eligibility overlap (between July 1st and end of the summer operational period), they must have their enrollment in the immediately prior school year confirmed at the time of application to establish eligibility for the current summer's benefit and checked again against enrollment for the new school year to establish eligibility for the following summer's benefit. The household or income information on the application does not need to be updated or recertified, but the child's enrollment in a qualifying school during each period of eligibility must be confirmed prior to issuing benefits for that program year.

VERIFICATION REQUIREMENTS

SEBT applications are subject to verification requirements for cause or for sample.

Exception: If an application that was submitted during the period of eligibility overlap was selected for verification, that application should not be verified again for the next program year including the same pool for the verification sample.

Verification for cause:

- When there is conflicting or inconsistent information from what was provided on the application(s).
- Can be requested at any time during the instructional year or summer operational period.
- Verification must be returned within 10 days of verification request.

Verification for sample:

- Applications are selected randomly from all the approved applications received. Three percent of the total applications from both paper and online will be verified.
- Verification can be requested once the processing of applications begins for the year of eligibility being determined.
- Benefits cannot be issued for applications selected for verification until the verification process is completed.

Households must be notified in writing that their application was selected. They are sent a verification checklist via email (if applicable) or mail, requesting information with a 10-day due date. An attempt to contact the household via phone will be made on the 7th day. If a household refuses to cooperate with efforts to verify, SEBT benefits must be denied.

Direct Verification

Direct verification is verifying a household's income at any point during the period of eligibility by matching against an applicable program (FAP, TANF, FDPIR or MA) used in streamlined certification.

The information provided only needs to indicate eligibility at a single point in time during the instructional year. The child does not have to be eligible at the time of application or verification. Direct verification must be conducted prior to contacting households that are selected as part of a random verification sample or for verification for cause.

Sources of Verification

Sources of verification may include written evidence, individuals outside of the child's household who can verify the child's circumstances, and applicable MDHHS assistance programs. The documentation must indicate the source, amount and frequency of all household income.

- Written evidence must be used as the primary source of information for verifications, such as pay stubs, award letters, and letters from employers.

- Verbal confirmations of the household's circumstances by a person outside of the household may be made over the phone. Individuals outside of the household who can verify the child's circumstances could include, but are not limited to; employers, social service agencies, school officials, and migrant agencies.
- Information concerning income, household size, or FAP, TANF or FDPIR, must be used to confirm household's income, size or receipt of benefits, as applicable. Information may also be obtained from individuals or agencies serving categorically eligible children, including foster, homeless, migrant, or runaway children.

Households which dispute the validity of income information acquired through an individual outside of the child's household or a system of records must be given the opportunity to provide other documentation.

BENEFIT

A one-time lump sum benefit per child will be issued for the months of June, July, and August. The issuance will be staggered over a 5-to-10-day period. The benefit will be adjusted each year to reflect changes in the cost of food measured by the Thrifty Food Plan. For children who can be streamlined certified or who have an approved Summer EBT application on file, before the summer operational period begins, benefits must be issued and available for participants to use at least 7 calendar days and no more than 14 calendar days before the start of the summer operational period. For eligible children who apply after the summer operational period begins, benefits must be issued and available to spend no later than 15 business days after a complete application is received by MDHHS.

Households who are enrolled through streamlined certification can opt-out of participation in the program.

Food purchased with SEBT benefits are eligible to be replaced when the household reports that food purchased with SEBT benefits were destroyed in a household misfortune or disaster. The benefit amount to be replaced is the lesser of the amount lost (as estimated by the household) or an amount equal to three months of benefits. MDHHS has the discretion to request additional evidence from a household to substantiate a questionable request.

EBT CARDS

Students will be issued benefits in one of the following ways:

1. Benefits for children on existing FAP, TANF, or FDPIR groups will be placed on the head of household's Bridge card associated with the case.
2. Benefits for children in an existing MA group will be placed on a card in the head of household's name and include all eligible children in the group. If the head of household has an existing Summer EBT card, it will be added to that card. If there is no existing card, then a new Summer EBT card will be issued.
3. Benefits for children enrolled in the NSLP/SBP and found eligible through the SEBT application who have an existing Summer EBT card from 2025 or later, will be added to the existing card. If there is no existing Summer EBT card, a new card will be issued for each individual child.

Student information provided from MDE and from MDHHS will need to match exactly for the benefit to be provided on a FAP, TANF, FDPIR, or MA case with MDHHS. If the student information does not match exactly to a case, the benefit will be issued to an individual card. Issued cards cannot be forwarded to current address if a forwarding address is on file with the United States Postal Service. SEBT cards issued in 2025 will be used to issue future benefits to eligible students for the program. For any lost or stolen card, parent/guardian can contact EBT Customer Service at 888-678-8914 for a replacement.

Address Used

The EBT card will be sent to the current mailing address on file with MDHHS or the school. For the address to be used that is on file with MDHHS, the student information must match exactly with the information on the case (i.e.: first name, last name, date of birth, and zip code). If any part of the information provided does not match what is on the case, the address used will be what was provided from MDE.

For children that are unsheltered, the card will be sent to the last school on file.

To update an address, contact the SEBT call center by phone or email.

Call Center Phone: 1-833-905-0028, Monday through Friday from 9:00 am – 3:00 pm.

Email: MDHHS-SEBT@michigan.gov.

DUPLICATE BENEFITS

Children may not receive benefits from more than one state or more than one \$120 benefit from Michigan. Should any instances of dual participation come to the State's attention, they will be investigated swiftly and thoroughly based on cost effective measures and in accordance with SEBT claims against households.

NOTICES

A notice of approval will be sent to all eligible children either individually or by household depending on how the benefits were issued.

The notice of eligibility will include a general explanation of the SEBT program, who is eligible for the program, benefit amount, how to set the PIN, how to check balances, how to request a replacement card, where the benefit can be used, who to contact for questions, and a way to apply for missing payments.

EXPUNGEMENT

The SEBT benefit, in its entirety, must be used within 122 days after the issuance date. The 122-day count begins the day after the benefits are available to spend. Benefits will be expunged on the 122nd day after benefit issuance, therefore benefits must be used by 11:59 p.m. on the 121st day. Regardless, if they were partially used or recently used, after 122 days the benefit will be expunged. If the SEBT benefit was issued to an existing Bridge card, the system will automatically use the SEBT benefit before using other benefits. If a card is returned as undeliverable mail and a replacement card is sent, the benefits are not technically "re-issued" and therefore the expungement clock is not reset. A letter will be issued to the client no later than 45 days prior to the benefits being expunged that provides the expungement date and benefit amount that is scheduled for expungement. Expunged benefits shall not be reinstated.

Note: Expungement means the removal of SEBT benefits from the EBT account to which they were issued.

HEARINGS

Clients have the right to contest a MDHHS decision affecting SEBT eligibility including an application the household has made for SEBT benefits, a streamlined certification for SEBT benefits, or a verification process or procedure, if they believe the decision is incorrect. The client or AHR has 90 calendar days from the date of the written notice of case action to request a hearing. The request must be received in writing by MDHHS within the 90 days (BAM 600).

Hearings policy for SEBT can be found in Bridges Administrative Manual (BAM), [see BAM 600, Hearings](#).

PROGRAM VIOLATIONS

MDHHS will investigate complaints received or irregularities noted during the implementation of the SEBT program. Issues that require in-depth review will be forward to the MDHHS Office of Inspector General for further analysis. If complaints or irregularities are substantiated, recoupment of SEBT benefits may be initiated, following current FAP regulations, see [BAM 720, Intentional Program Violation](#).

RESOURCES

For more information on the Summer EBT Program see:
<https://www.michigan.gov/mdhhs/assistance-programs/food/summer-ebt>

Call Center Phone: 1-833-905-0028, Monday through Friday from 9:00 am – 3:00 pm.

Email: MDHHS-SEBT@michigan.gov

During non-business hours, parents can leave a voicemail or send an email. Voicemails and emails will be addressed within two business days.

In addition, the EBT customer service, 888-678-8914, is available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week to assist clients with card issues.

LEGAL BASE

7 CFR 292.2 2.2 (definitions)
7 CFR 202.5 (general purpose)

7 CFR 292.6 (eligibility)
7 CFR 292.12(f)(1) (approved application notice)
7 CFR 292.12(g) (denied application notice)
7 CFR 292.13(g) (application deadline)
7 CFR 292.13(h) (electronic application)
7 CFR 292.13(i) (application content requirements)
7 CFR 292.13(j) (attesting information on application)
7 CFR 292.14 (verification requirements)
7 CFR 292.15(c) (benefit issuance)
7 CFR 292.15(c)(2) (method of issuance)
7 CFR 292.15(e)(benefit amount)
7 CFR 292.15(g)(5) (replacement benefit)
7 CFR 292.15(h)(1) (expungement)
7 CFR 292.27 2.28 (program violations)
7 CFR 292.8(e)(12) and 292.26 Required Attachments (hearings)